

UNIVERSITY OF ESSEX

Undergraduate Examination 2025

RETHINKING MODERNITY

Time allowed: **THREE** hours

An open-book exam allows you to refer to your notes and other course materials while you are taking the exam. Open-book exams are designed to test your ability to analyse, evaluate or synthesise knowledge, rather than your ability to recall facts or information.

You may bring physical written or printed notes, textbooks, dictionaries or course materials into the exam room. Please note that your materials must fit on a small desk and you are advised to bring well-structured notes based on revision topics.

You may not bring electronic devices except calculators of the following types only: Casio FX-83GT or Casio FX-85GT series only (CW, X, PLUS). All Sociology exams will be paper-based and hand-written.

Candidates must answer **THREE** questions in total. **ONE** from **SECTION A**, **ONE** from **SECTION B**, and **ONE** other from **EITHER SECTION**.

The paper consists of **SIXTEEN** questions in total.

All questions are of equal weight.

Please do not leave your seat unless you are given permission by an invigilator. Do not communicate in any way with any other candidate in the examination room. Do not open the question paper until told to do so.

All answers must be written in the answer book(s) provided.

All rough work must be written in the answer book(s) provided.

A line should be drawn through any rough work to indicate to the examiner that it is not part of the work to be marked.

At the end of the examination, remain seated until your answer book(s) have been collected and you have been told you may leave.

Your response must be your own work. Procedures are in place to detect plagiarism.

This paper is restricted and must not be removed from the examination room. Please use treasury tag to attach question paper to answer booklet.

Candidates must answer **THREE** questions: **ONE from SECTION A, ONE from SECTION B,** and **ONE** other from **EITHER SECTION**.

SECTION A

1. Is it possible to fully understand modernity without understanding the role of colonialism in its development?
2. 'Sociology is the study of human societies.' Critically assess this statement using the ideas set out by Carter and Charles in the key reading for this topic.
3. 'The fact-value distinction is a cornerstone of modernity. It is also one of its major problems.' Critically assess this statement.
4. 'Language, power and modernity are all interrelated.' Critically analyse this statement.
5. Outline and assess the political importance of feminism today.
6. To what extent does contemporary capitalism utilise elements of taste and/or morality?
7. Using the work of at least two authors, explain why the global distribution of wealth/income is an important topic for sociology.
8. Why is the concept of perspectives important for understanding the status of epistemology within modernity?

END OF SECTION A

SECTION B

9. How did Foucault challenge traditional sociological approaches to power? How convincing do you find his arguments?
10. What is meant by 'scientific racism'? How have sociologists tried to counter this concept?
11. How have post-colonial theorists challenged the distinction between 'the West and the Rest'?
12. Donna Haraway stated that 'How we see the world is always a matter of power'. Explain this statement and its relevance for sociology today.
13. Outline and assess if Southern theory addresses inequalities in the Global South.
14. Critically analyze the connection between European modernity and the climate crisis.
15. Critically discuss two aspects of the Gandhian view on technology.
16. Outline and assess the concept of 'multiple modernities.'

END OF SECTION B

END OF PAPER